OTHER WORSHIPPERS OF GOD

The residents of Fatehpur Sikri had become used to the presence of unusual visitors at their court but the arrival of sixty-seven Jain monks in a whispering procession, heralded by drummers and singers in 1583, must have nonetheless caused a considerable stir. '[Jains monks] wear nothing on the head and pluck out the hairs of chins and heads, leaving only a tuft,' wrote a bemused European traveller to Hindustan about the Jains. They were 'more European than Indian in colour', noted the traveller, and tied a cloth over their mouths. They carried brooms, and swept the ground clean of ants and other tiny insects as they walked. This silent procession of austere men included Hiravijaya Suri an orphan and a monk since the age of thirteen, whom, as we have seen, Akbar had invited to his court. The distinguished monk brought with him followers from the relatively minor Tapa Gaccha sect. In the poem *Jagadgurukavya*, the earliest Sanskrit text describing the Jain experience at Akbar's court, Hiravijaya is described as 'foremost among the dispassionate, best of ascetics, who had the form of glorious khuda', which was, as Truschke describes it, a flagrant adoption of Islamic hierarchy when invoking the Persian name of God (khuda) for Hiravijaya.

A Jain text, the *Hirasaubhagya*, written in the early seventeenth century, described the supposed meeting between the two scholars, Abu'l Fazl and Hiravijaya. According to Truschke, this text contains a rare, unabashed description of Islamic beliefs in Sanskrit, which had always tended to scuff out the presence of Islam in religious discourse. The conversation between the two men is transcribed in Sanskrit and Abu'l Fazl begins by describing the tenets of Islam, and asks about the validity of a creator God, a Heaven and Hell, and resurrection at the end of the world:

> O Suri, this was laid out by the ancient prophets in our scriptures—all Muslims who are deposited on earth as guests of the god of death will rise at the end of the earth and come before the court of the Supreme Lord called khuda, just as they come to the court of an earthly king… O Suri, what is the validity of the Quranic speech: is